Participant Information Sheet

Dear participant,

You have been invited to take part in this research study titled **Gendered Institutions, Entrepreneurial Ecosystems and Women's Differentiated Access to and Participation in Selected High-Growth Sectors in Nigeria**

Please read this information before deciding whether to take part.

What is the purpose of the study?

The study examines how formal rules, informal expectations and entrepreneurial ecosystem arrangements shape women's opportunity to enter, participate and grow within selected high-growth sectors in Nigeria. It considers access to finance, markets, regulation, procurement, support organizations, networks and legitimacy, and how these conditions may vary by sector and by women's roles as founders, owners and leaders.

Why have you been invited to take part in the research?

You may have been invited because you are aged 18 or over and have direct experience relevant to entrepreneurship in a high-growth sector in Nigeria. You may be a woman who is or has been a founder, co-founder, owner, co-owner or strategic leader; a woman whose attempt to enter or build a venture was stalled, blocked or ended; an ecosystem actor who allocates or facilitates resources or opportunities; or a policy or sector informant with direct design, implementation, regulatory or coordination knowledge.

The study focuses on sectors that show a credible orientation towards innovation, growth, investment, market expansion or scale.

Key definitions:

High growth sector: A sector associated with innovation, scaling, investment or structural transformation; distinct from a firm that meets a growth-rate threshold

What will participation involve?

You will be first asked to complete a short pre-screening questionnaire, which should take about 5 to 7 minutes. It helps identify the most relevant interview guide and supports a varied sample. Following this, a semi structured interview will be conducted in person or online depending on what is most practical.

How long will it take

The interview will usually take 60 to 90 minutes. You will be asked about your role, significant events and decisions, access to resources or opportunities, formal requirements, informal expectations, ecosystem relationships and support arrangements. You may be invited to

discuss a simple timeline or process. You are not expected to disclose confidential information that you are not authorised to share, or identify third parties unnecessarily. With your permission, the interview will be audio recorded so that an accurate transcript can be prepared. You may take part without video. Recording will not begin until your consent is confirmed.

What information will be required from me?

The study may collect your name, gender and contact details for recruitment and scheduling as well as support the description of the demographics of our sample; screening information about eligibility, role, sector, location and relevant experience; the audio recording and transcript of the interview; and optional background information used to understand sample variation. You may choose 'prefer not to say' for optional questions.

Contact details, consent records and research data will be kept separately. Research files will use a participant code rather than your name.

How will the data be stored and used?

All data will be anonymised, kept confidential and securely stored, with only an anonymous identifiers used where relevant.

All data will be securely stored on the researcher's university OneDrive for security and never shared with anyone outside the research team. Data will be destroyed after four years as part of the International Data Protection Act. Neither your name nor your organisation's name will be included in the research findings. Direct quotes may be used, but they will remain anonymous. The research team anticipates using the research findings to produce outputs like reports, academic papers, book chapters, case studies, etc.

Who can I contact about data privacy and storage?

The organisation responsible for protection of your personal information is the University of Reading (the Data Controller). Queries regarding data protection and your rights should be directed to the University Data Protection Officer at imps@reading.ac.uk , or in writing to: University of Reading, Information Management & Policy Services, Whiteknights House, Pepper Lane, Whiteknights, Reading , RG6 6UR, UK.

The University of Reading collects, analyses, uses, shares and retains personal data for the purposes of research in the public interest. Under data protection law we are required to inform you that this use of the personal data we may hold about you is on the lawful basis of being a public task in the public interest and where it is necessary for scientific or historical research purposes. If you withdraw from a research study, which processes your personal data, dependant on the stage of withdrawal, we may still rely on this lawful basis to continue using your data if your withdrawal would be of significant detriment to the research study aims. We will always have in place appropriate safeguards to protect your personal data.

If we have included any additional requests for use of your data, for example adding you to a registration list for the purposes of inviting you to take part in future studies, this will be done only with your consent where you have provided it to us and should you wish to be removed from the register at a later date, you should contact: mary.ukam@pgr.reading.ac.uk .

You have certain rights under data protection law which are:

- Withdraw your consent, for example if you opted in to be added to a participant register
- Access your personal data or ask for a copy
- Rectify inaccuracies in personal data that we hold about you
- Be forgotten, that is your details to be removed from systems that we use to process your personal data
- Restrict uses of your data
- Object to uses of your data, for example retention after you have withdrawn from a study

Some restrictions apply to the above rights where data is collected and used for research purposes. You can find out more about your rights on the website of the Information Commissioners Office (ICO) at https://ico.org.uk

You also have a right to complain the ICO if you are unhappy with how your data has been handled. Please contact the University Data Protection Officer in the first instance.

Are there any risks in participating?

There are no foreseeable risks or disadvantages expected from taking part in this study.

Is there a cost, benefits, or compensation?

Your participation is voluntary and there is no cost, reimbursement or compensation involved. You may withdraw at any time without having to give any reason. Please feel free to ask any questions that you may have about this study at any point.

While there is no direct personal benefit, your participation will contribute to improving the understanding of how women entrepreneurs in Nigeria navigate rules, practices, networks and support arrangements to enter, participate and grow businesses in selected high-growth sectors.

Has the research received Ethics approval?

This study has been reviewed by the Ethics Office, Henley Business School, University of Reading, UK and has been given a favourable ethical approval for conduct.

Where can I get more information/who I can contact about this study?

If you have any questions or concerns about the research, please feel free to contact:

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Thank you for reading this information and for considering participation in our study.